Middle East Defense Architecture

CENTCOM, Iron Dome, F-35, and the Regional Arms Race

Blue Lotus Research Intelligence | August 2026

Classification: Open Intelligence

Executive Summary

The Middle East constitutes the primary theatre of US forward military deployment outside of Europe and the Pacific, with between 40,000 and 65,000 US military personnel maintained across more than 30 bases and facilities within the CENTCOM Area of Responsibility . The architecture of this presence — the 5th Fleet at Bahrain, the CENTCOM forward headquarters at Al-Udeid Air Base in Qatar, the advanced Al Dhafra facility in the UAE, and significant ground force concentrations in Kuwait and Iraq — reflects a strategic design constructed over five decades of incremental expansion following the 1979 Iranian Revolution, the 1990 Gulf War, and the 2003 Iraq invasion.

The Defence Security Cooperation Agency reported more than $50 billion in US arms sales to MENA nations across FY2020-2024 , with Saudi Arabia consistently ranked as the world's largest arms importer by the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute for the period 2019-2023 . The primary driver of this arms investment is the Iranian ballistic missile and drone threat — a programme that has grown from a modest 1980s Scud-derivative force into the largest and most diverse ballistic missile arsenal in the Middle East, complemented by an expanding drone production capacity that has proven its operational effectiveness against Gulf infrastructure and in multiple proxy conflicts . Against this threat environment, Israel maintains the qualitatively superior regional military, anchored by the most advanced layered air defence system in the world, a fleet of F-35I Adir aircraft, and an intelligence enterprise whose commercial and operational outputs reshape the regional security landscape.

Part I — US Military Posture: The CENTCOM Architecture

US Central Command encompasses 21 countries stretching from Egypt through Central Asia, constituting the most geopolitically active geographic responsibility in the US global military structure. General Michael Kurilla commanded CENTCOM from 2022 through 2025, overseeing simultaneous management of the October 7 crisis response, the Houthi Red Sea campaign, residual counterterrorism operations in Syria and Iraq, and sustained deterrence posture toward Iran .

CENTCOM's forward headquarters at Al-Udeid Air Base in Qatar hosts more than 10,000 US military personnel, B-52 strategic bomber rotational deployments, MQ-9 Reaper UAV operations, and over 120 aircraft comprising the Air Operations Centre that coordinates US air operations across the entire Middle East . The facility is the largest US air base in the Middle East and has functioned as the operational nerve centre for every US military campaign in the region since the 1990s. Qatar's willingness to host this infrastructure despite its concurrent financial and political support for Hamas — a relationship that creates significant US policy tensions — reflects the transactional pragmatism that characterises Gulf security relationships.

Naval Support Activity Bahrain hosts the US 5th Fleet, which manages approximately 7,000 US Navy personnel and coordinates carrier strike group operations throughout the Middle East, including mine countermeasures squadrons and the multinational coalition forces that operate under 5th Fleet authority in the Persian Gulf . Al Dhafra Air Base in the UAE, hosting approximately 7,500 US personnel, is assessed as the most technically advanced US military installation in the region, supporting F-22 Raptor and U-2 reconnaissance aircraft deployments that perform intelligence collection across the entire MENA theatre . The Kuwaiti garrison, concentrated at Camp Arifjan, maintains 13,000 or more US Army personnel under the Army's Central Command (ARCENT) forward headquarters, representing the primary US Army ground combat power in the region .

The October 7, 2023 Hamas attack on Israel and the subsequent conflict forced an unprecedented US military response. CENTCOM deployed the USS Gerald R. Ford Carrier Strike Group and the USS Dwight D. Eisenhower Carrier Strike Group simultaneously to the Eastern Mediterranean and Red Sea — a dual-carrier deployment not seen since the Iraq War and representing a deliberate demonstration of deterrent intent aimed at preventing Hezbollah and Iran from opening additional conflict fronts . The USS Theodore Roosevelt and Carl Vinson subsequently rotated through the theatre. The United States deployed Terminal High Altitude Area Defense (THAAD) to Israel for the first time in its operational history — the first deployment of THAAD outside US military control — alongside Patriot air defence reinforcements for Jordan and Saudi Arabia .

Part II — Saudi Arabia's Arms Buildup: The Architecture of Gulf Deterrence

---

Saudi Arabia's status as the world's largest arms importer for the period 2019-2023 reflects a defence investment programme of extraordinary scale that has been driven by the combination of OPEC+ oil revenues, the Iranian ballistic missile and drone threat demonstrated by the September 2019 Abqaiq attack, and the institutional imperative of Vision 2030's domestic defence industrialisation agenda. SIPRI's Transfer of Imports Value data records $25.4 billion in Saudi arms imports for 2019-2023, with the United States accounting for approximately 78% of the total .

The cornerstone of Saudi air power is the F-15SA acquisition programme: a deal for 84 new aircraft and upgrades of 70 existing F-15S aircraft valued at approximately $29.4 billion, contracted with Boeing and delivered through 2019 . The Royal Saudi Air Force operates over 300 combat aircraft in total, making it one of the region's largest and most capable air forces. Patriot PAC-3 MSE air defence systems were acquired from Lockheed Martin, and negotiations for the THAAD terminal high-altitude system were advanced through a $15 billion notification in 2017, though delivery timelines were complicated by US production constraints . The UK contributed 72 Eurofighter Typhoon aircraft through the Al-Salam programme with BAE Systems at a value of approximately $8.4 billion .

Saudi ground forces operate the M1A2S Abrams main battle tank (153 vehicles, approximately $4.2 billion) and AH-64 Apache attack helicopters (24 aircraft, approximately $3.2 billion) . Total Royal Saudi Land Forces strength exceeds 200,000 personnel with over 900 tanks. The 2022 Saudi defence budget was reported at $75 billion by the Saudi Ministry of Finance , though actual security expenditure including internal security forces is higher.

Vision 2030's defence industrialisation target — 50% domestic procurement by 2030 from a baseline of approximately 2% in 2016 — has driven the establishment of the General Authority for Military Industries (GAMI) and Saudi Arabian Military Industries (SAMI), which operate joint ventures with Lockheed Martin Saudi Arabia, Raytheon Saudi Arabia, MBDA, and other international prime contractors . The transfer of technology and localisation of production required to meet the 50% target has become a primary consideration in Saudi arms procurement negotiations.

Part III — Israeli Defense: The Qualitative Regional Leader

The Israel Defense Forces represent the qualitatively superior military capability in the Middle East by virtually every dimension of assessment — technology, training, intelligence integration, and operational experience. The Israeli Air Force operates 50 delivered F-35I Adir aircraft, with a total of 75 on order, constituting the largest F-35 fleet outside the United States and United Kingdom . The F-35I variant includes Israeli-specific modifications to electronic warfare systems and weapon integration that the United States has agreed to accommodate — a concession reflecting Israel's unique status as a US security partner.

Israel's layered air defence architecture is the most comprehensive in the world. Iron Dome, co-developed with Raytheon and Rafael, provides short-range intercept against rockets, mortars, and short-range missiles with an assessed effectiveness rate exceeding 90% across the Gaza conflict . Ten Iron Dome batteries are operational alongside 20 additional launcher units. David's Sling, a medium-range system developed by Rafael with Raytheon, bridges the gap between Iron Dome and the Arrow system against ballistic missiles and cruise missiles . The Arrow-3 exo-atmospheric interceptor — co-developed with Boeing — was tested against Iranian ballistic missiles during the April 2024 Iranian direct attack on Israel, demonstrating operational capability against incoming ballistic missiles outside the atmosphere . Arrow-3 was sold to Germany in a landmark $3.5 billion deal in 2023, marking the first sale of the system to a European buyer and the first sale outside Israel's own inventory .

The Iron Beam high-energy laser system — under development by Rafael — represents a potentially transformative development in the economics of air defence. With an intercept cost of approximately $1 per shot against rockets and UAVs, compared to approximately $50,000 per Tamir interceptor missile used by Iron Dome, Iron Beam addresses the fundamental cost-exchange problem that has favoured Iranian-supplied mass-volume attacks over US-supplied Israeli interceptors . Operational deployment of Iron Beam was in progress as of 2024 .

Israeli defense exports reached $13.1 billion in 2022, placing Israel second only to the United States and Russia as a defence exporter as a percentage of GDP . The Merkava Mk.4M tank with Trophy Active Protection System, Harop loitering munitions, Spike anti-tank missiles, and Hermes series UAVs constitute Israel's most commercially successful export platforms. The Spike missile family alone has been adopted by over 30 nations.

Part IV — Iranian Ballistic Missiles and the Asymmetric Threat

Iran operates the largest and most diverse ballistic missile programme in the Middle East, a capability built deliberately over four decades as an asymmetric deterrent to Israeli and US conventional superiority. The programme encompasses short-range, medium-range, and intermediate-range systems across both liquid and solid propellant technologies, giving Iran a complex strike capability that complicates interception planning.

The Shahab-3, derived from the North Korean Nodong with a range of approximately 1,300 kilometres, represents the foundational tier of Iran's ballistic missile force . The Qiam-1, a medium-range ballistic missile of approximately 800-kilometre range, uses liquid propellant and serves as a precision-strike system against regional targets. The Khorramshahr, with a range of approximately 2,000 kilometres and claimed multiple re-entry vehicle capability, extends Iranian strike range to cover most of Europe's southeastern extremity if launched from western Iranian territory . The Sejjil, a 2,000-kilometre solid-propellant system, provides faster-reaction capability than liquid-fuelled systems. Iran's Fattah-1 hypersonic glide vehicle — announced with claimed Mach 15 terminal velocity and first tested in June 2023 — if functional, would represent a significant capability against existing ballistic missile defence systems .

The April 2024 Iranian direct attack on Israel — the first ever direct Iranian attack on Israeli territory — deployed over 110 ballistic missiles of the Emad, Ghadr, and Shahab variants, alongside cruise missiles and UAVs, in a coordinated salvo . The Israeli multilayer air defence, supported by US, UK, French, and Jordanian military assets, intercepted the ballistic missile component with near-total effectiveness according to IDF assessments . The attack demonstrated both Iranian operational capability and the current limitations of ballistic missile effectiveness against a well-prepared multilayer defence.

Iran's Shahed-136 kamikaze drone — supplied to Russia for use in Ukraine — has transformed the global drone warfare calculus. More than 2,000 Shahed-136 units were supplied by Iran to Russia by February 2024, at an estimated unit cost of $40,000 to $50,000 . The economic logic — a $40,000 drone requiring a $1 million-plus intercept missile — creates a cost-exchange ratio that favours the attacker, and this same logic applies across the Iranian proxy network from Yemen to Iraq to Lebanon. Iranian drone derivatives have been documented in Houthi operations against Red Sea shipping and in Iraqi militia attacks on US bases.

Part V — Regional Arms Race Dynamics and the Architecture of Deterrence

The September 14, 2019 attack on the Abqaiq and Khurais oil processing facilities — which briefly removed 5.7 million barrels per day of Saudi oil production from global markets, the largest single temporary disruption to global oil supply in history — demonstrated the operational effectiveness of Iran's combined drone and cruise missile threat against Gulf infrastructure . The United States attributed responsibility to Iran; Iran denied involvement and Houthi forces initially claimed credit. The attack had immediate consequences for Saudi air defence investment, driving urgency behind THAAD acquisition and Patriot modernisation.

UAE's F-35 acquisition illustrates the complex intersection of arms sales, technology controls, and geopolitical alignment. The sale of 50 F-35 aircraft for approximately $23 billion was announced in September 2020 as part of the Abraham Accords framework . The deal subsequently became entangled in US concerns about UAE's Huawei 5G network infrastructure: the United States demanded that UAE remove Huawei equipment from government and sensitive networks as a condition of F-35 delivery, a requirement UAE declined to accept . UAE suspended the F-35 deal in December 2021 and the agreement was effectively cancelled by May 2023 . In its place, UAE signed a contract with France for 80 Rafale fighters at approximately $20 billion in December 2021, and entered parallel Eurofighter negotiations .

Turkey's Bayraktar TB2 armed drone, produced by Baykar Makina and deployed operationally in Libya, Ukraine, Ethiopia, and Nagorno-Karabakh, has fundamentally altered the asymmetric warfare calculus for middle-power militaries at a unit cost of approximately $1-2 million — affordable for states that cannot procure F-35s . Saudi Arabia has evaluated TB2 acquisition, and Morocco, Pakistan, and Poland have completed purchases. The TB2 represents the democratisation of effective armed drone capability, and its proliferation through the MENA region is reshaping ground force tactical calculations.

Informal Israel-Saudi air defence coordination represents perhaps the most consequential unacknowledged security relationship in the current regional order. Israeli and Saudi air defence radars both monitor Iranian ballistic missile launches and could, with appropriate communication protocols, share tracking data — a capability integration that the United States has explicitly worked to facilitate as part of the strategic framework around the now-suspended Israel-Saudi normalisation negotiations . The logic is straightforward: an Iranian ballistic missile strike coordinated across multiple theatre targets simultaneously — Israel, Saudi Arabia, UAE — would stress any single state's defence capacity, while coordinated data-sharing and potentially coordinated intercept operations would improve overall defensive effectiveness. Whether this informal coordination survived October 7 in operational rather than merely conceptual form has not been publicly confirmed.

Conclusion

The US CENTCOM architecture provides the foundational security guarantee underpinning Gulf state stability, and every dimension of the regional arms race — from Saudi F-15SA acquisitions to UAE Rafale orders to Israeli Arrow-3 deployments — is oriented around the primary threat vector of Iranian ballistic missiles, drones, and proxy forces. The Iranian asymmetric model — combining cost-effective drone production with proxy network investment — forces the region's US-aligned states into defensive expenditure at a cost-exchange ratio that systematically favours Iran. Israel maintains the qualitative regional military edge through F-35I and layered air defence investments that no other regional actor can replicate. The arms race logic is accelerating rather than stabilising, driven by the absence of any viable diplomatic framework for constraining Iranian missile and drone capabilities, and by the demonstrated operational effectiveness of Iranian-supplied systems in every current MENA conflict.

Blue Lotus Research Intelligence | Middle East Series | August 2026 | Open Intelligence. All figures drawn from publicly available institutional sources. No proprietary data. Produced for strategic research purposes.